PAGEANT QUEENS, 1994

THE BEAUTY BOOMERS

India's lovely lasses and global beauty pageants, it's been a match made in heaven since the 1990s. And it isn't just looks, many title winners have blazed a winning trail in later careers

BY SUHANI SINGH

The year was 1994 and India was feeling bold and beautiful. Two young models—one just 18, the other 21—were responsible for that state of mind. Two years after Madhu Sapre missed the Miss Universe crown by a whisker, Sushmita Sen brought it home, becoming the first Indian to win the title. But Sushmita was the surprise all through, in Aishwarya Rai's case, the surprise was that she lost the top spot to Sushmita in the Miss India pageant, the Miss World title was hers to win. Their wins bestowed on them moviestar status—indeed they soon became actors—but more than anything, they and their peers inspired countless young women to choose modelling. Just like that, modelling became a profession to aspire to.

Arriving as they did when liberalisation was opening us up to a new world of possibilities, the back-to-back victories were transformative in making Indian women curious about beauty aspects like skincare, fitness and diet. The number of applications for Miss India skyrocketed, many coming from the stifling small towns of the country. Supermodel contests grew by the dozen as international modelling agencies came scouting for talent. The next few years were India's, with a number of desi beauties winning beauty titles one after the other.

By the dawn of the new century, India



THE SUMMIT Sushmita Sen wins the Miss Universe crown, Manila, 1994

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